

English Language · Medium paper

Real VCAA questions ranked by the published state results. Editable: type your answers straight into this PDF, save it, then mark yourself with the guide at the back.

Name _____ Date _____

75 marks

reading 15 min · writing 120 min

State average on these questions

40 / 75 (53%)

a student at the state average on every question

How to use this paper

1. Open each question with its blue link. It opens the official VCAA exam PDF at the right page. The question text isn't reproduced here because it is VCAA copyright (some exams include third-party material).
2. Answer in this file: click a bubble for multiple choice, and type in the boxes for written answers (long answers scroll inside the box). Methods and science working can be typed in plain text, e.g. $v = \sqrt{2gh} = 9.9 \text{ m/s}$.
3. Keep to the real time limits above, and don't look at the guide until you've finished.
4. Save with Ctrl/Cmd + S. Use a PDF app that supports forms: Adobe Acrobat Reader, Chrome, Edge, Firefox, macOS Preview or Xodo.
5. Mark yourself: in the guide at the back, tick each marking point you earned, enter your marks, and compare your total with the state average.

Why these questions

Every section is a real VCAA exam section. English sections can't be split question by question, because each is built around one text, so Sections A, B and C from the 2023, 2024 and 2025 exams were ranked by state average and this paper takes the middle version of each section. English results barely move between years, so the three English papers are close in difficulty. VCAA reports Sections B and C on a 0–15 scale, so the averages are doubled to match the 30 marks on the paper.

Sources

- [2024 English Language exam \(PDF\)](#) · [examiners' report](#)
- [2025 English Language exam \(PDF\)](#) · [examiners' report](#)

Section A – Short-answer questions (15 marks)

All questions refer to Text 1 in the insert of the 2025 exam. Open the insert and each question with the links.

Section A (15 marks)

2025 VCAA exam · Insert, Text 1 · [open in the official exam PDF \(p. 30\)](#) ↗

Text 1: an email from the head of a reusable-bottle company to a customer

Question 1. Identify one modal verb between lines 29 and 39 and describe how it supports a purpose of the text (metalinguage). ([p. 3](#) ↗) (3 marks)

Question 2. Identify two examples of information flow between lines 20 and 33, and describe the impact of one (metalinguage). ([p. 3](#) ↗) (3 marks)

Question 3. Identify one semantic pattern and one syntactic pattern and explain how each reflects a different function of the text (Jakobson). ([p. 4](#) ↗) (4 marks)

Question 4. Using at least three examples of the writer's language, analyse how register achieves a range of purposes and intents, with reference to cultural context (line numbers). [\(p. 5 ↗\)](#) (5 marks)

Section B – Analytical commentary (30 marks)

Write an analytical commentary on Text 2 in the insert of the 2025 exam: function, purpose and intent; situational and cultural context; register, tenor and audience; and relevant language features from at least two subsystems.

Section B (30 marks)

2025 VCAA exam · Section B · Question 5 · [open in the official exam PDF \(p. 6\)](#) ↗

Insert: [Text 2](#) ↗

Text 2: a transcript of an Indigenous surgeon's award acceptance speech to a live audience

Analytical commentary on Text 2 (30 marks)

Section C – Essay (30 marks)

Write one essay on one of the three topics. Open the topic in the official exam for the exact wording and stimulus material.

Section C (30 marks)

2024 VCAA exam · Section C (choose one of Questions 7, 8, 9) · [open in the official exam PDF \(p. 14\)](#) ↗

Choose one topic.

1. **Question 7.** Language defines Australian identity, and its use keeps changing: discuss. ([exact wording and stimulus, p. 14](#) ↗)
2. **Question 8.** Our choice of variety of Australian English can both support and undermine our purposes in interactions: discuss. ([exact wording and stimulus, p. 16](#) ↗)
3. **Question 9.** To what extent do register and politeness go hand in hand with social standing in contemporary Australia? ([exact wording and stimulus, p. 18](#) ↗)

Essay (name the topic you chose) (30 marks)

Essay (name the topic you chose) continued

END OF PAPER

Marking guide follows

Stop here until you have finished the paper under exam conditions.

Marking guide

Section A – Short-answer questions (15 marks)

Section A (15 marks) · state average 6.9 / 15 (46%)

2025 VCAA exam · Insert, Text 1

Question 1 · Identify one modal verb between lines 29 and 39 and describe how it supports a purpose of the text (metalinguage).

- ☐ An accurate modal verb from the line range (e.g. “will”, line 32; “couldn’t”, line 37; quasi-modal “going to”, line 34)
- ☐ Identifies a valid purpose (e.g. build rapport, reduce social distance, attend to face needs)
- ☐ Explains how the modal supports that purpose (e.g. high modality signals a firm commitment)

Answer / notes: “We will continue...” (32): high modality presents the company’s commitment as certain, building trust and rapport with the customer. Revise which words are modals, because many picked non-modals.

State average 1.9 / 3 (63%); 48% scored full marks. Mark distribution: 0: 26% · 1: 4% · 2: 22% · 3: 48%

Your mark: _____ / 3

Question 2 · Identify two examples of information flow between lines 20 and 33, and describe the impact of one (metalinguage).

- ☐ First accurate example of information flow (front or end focus) from the line range
- ☐ Second accurate example
- ☐ Describes the impact of one (e.g. places key information in prominence to support a purpose, or builds cohesion)

Answer / notes: For example, fronted adverbials such as “Alongside [partner]” (20) and “With your incredible support” (27) put the partnership and the customer in front focus, foregrounding shared effort. 67% scored zero, mostly from misidentifying information flow.

State average 0.8 / 3 (27%); 13% scored full marks. Mark distribution: 0: 67% · 1: 6% · 2: 13% · 3: 13%

Your mark: _____ / 3

Question 3 · Identify one semantic pattern and one syntactic pattern and explain how each reflects a different function of the text (Jakobson).

- ☐ A semantic pattern identified and labelled as semantic (e.g. metaphor “made waves”, 21, or “at the heart”, 45)
- ☐ Linked to one Jakobson function with explanation
- ☐ A syntactic pattern identified and labelled as syntactic (e.g. listing of new products, lines 10–11)
- ☐ Linked to a different function with explanation

Answer / notes: Listing (syntactic) serves the referential function by cataloguing products. A metaphor (semantic) serves the poetic or conative function. Name the subsystem as well as the pattern.

State average 2.2 / 4 (55%); 16% scored full marks. Mark distribution: 0: 16% · 1: 11% · 2: 34% · 3: 23% · 4: 16%

Your mark: _____ / 4

Question 4 · Using at least three examples of the writer’s language, analyse how register achieves a range of purposes and intents, with reference to cultural context (line numbers).

- ☐ Characterises the register accurately (a shifting mix of formal and informal)
- ☐ Example 1 analysed and linked to a purpose/intent
- ☐ Example 2 analysed and linked to a purpose/intent
- ☐ Example 3 analysed and linked to a purpose/intent
- ☐ Links to cultural context (values of the company and the customer, e.g. sustainability)

Answer / notes: Formal language lends legitimacy and prestige, while informal touches humanise the company and personalise the email. Connect the examples to each other and to the shared value of sustainability.

State average 2.0 / 5 (40%); 0.5% scored full marks. Mark distribution: 0: 10% · 1: 20% · 2: 38% · 3: 25% · 4: 6% · 5: 0.5%

Your mark: _____ / 5

Section B – Analytical commentary (30 marks)

Section B (30 marks) · state average 16.4 / 30 (55%)

2025 VCAA exam · Section B · Question 5

Analytical commentary on Text 2

____ / 8 · Function(s), purpose(s) and intent(s), situational and cultural context, and register, tenor and audience are analysed accurately and specifically for this text

____ / 10 · Salient language features from at least two subsystems are analysed with quoted examples and line numbers, each explicitly linked to function, context or register

____ / 6 · Precise, accurate metalanguage throughout

____ / 6 · A coherent, sustained commentary (not a feature list), with clear, controlled expression

Answer / notes: Rich in identity features: the surgeon's down-to-earth humility, occupational identity, Indigenous identity, wider Australian identity and family identity. Choose the most salient features and link each to function, purpose, context, register and audience, rather than listing features by subsystem.

State average 16.4 / 30 (55%). VCAA reports this section on a 0–15 scale (doubled here to /30): 0: 0.6% · 1: 0.1% · 2: 0.1% · 3: 0.7% · 4: 2% · 5: 4% · 6: 9% · 7: 17% · 8: 24% · 9: 21% · 10: 13% · 11: 6% · 12: 3% · 13: 1% · 14: 0.3% · 15: 0.1%

Your mark: ____ / 30

Section C – Essay (30 marks)

Section C (30 marks) · state average 16.8 / 30 (56%)

2024 VCAA exam · Section C (choose one of Questions 7, 8, 9)

Essay (name the topic you chose)

____ / 8 · A clear, sustained and nuanced contention that answers the exact wording of the topic (including “to what extent” where asked)

____ / 10 · Relevant, contemporary Australian examples discussed in depth, drawing on at least two subsystems of language, with thoughtful use of the stimulus

____ / 6 · Accurate linguistic concepts and metalanguage

____ / 6 · Cohesive essay structure and fluent, controlled expression

Answer / notes: Briefly contextualise each example. Essays with weak introductions rarely recovered, while clear, planned contentions scored well. Topic choice across the state: Q7 59%, Q8 29%, Q9 11%.

State average 16.8 / 30 (56%). VCAA reports this section on a 0–15 scale (doubled here to /30): 0: 0.6% · 1: 0.2% · 2: 0.3% · 3: 0.8% · 4: 1% · 5: 3% · 6: 9% · 7: 16% · 8: 23% · 9: 20% · 10: 13% · 11: 7% · 12: 4% · 13: 2% · 14: 0.5% · 15: 0.1%

Your mark: ____ / 30

Your result

Total: _____ / 75 State average on these questions: **40 / 75 (53%)**

Topics to revise:

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